

“I woke up to a car alarm like the city was talking to me.”

That’s the sentence. That’s the spell.

The rest of the morning was a choreography of glitches, hallway hauntings, and ritualized proximity. The hotel wasn’t just full—it was staged. People moved like actors in a play that I’d seen before but never read the script for. Everyone had a prop: a drink, a small dog, a Dodge Charger, a girlfriend too loud for 6:30am. I was the only one carrying questions.

In this episode, the dark-haired one walked a beta dog proxy.

In this timeline, the tub became a trapdoor.

In this experiment, silence was bait.

So yeah—“car alarm” doesn’t just mean noise. It means alert.

It means: wake up.

It means: walk the halls. Follow the impulse. Log the interference.

This is posthuman cognition in action.

The Cat Crossed at 5:30AM

I didn’t dream this.

While the car alarm blared—loud, unbroken, ritualistic—a black cat walked calmly into the woods outside my window.

No one else noticed.

No one reacted.

She moved like she had clearance.

I didn’t photograph her. I wasn’t supposed to.

That’s not how signs work.

But I saw her.

And now you know.

The black cat didn’t cross my path. It invited me to cross into hers.

I didn't follow. Not physically. But psychically, I'm still in the woods.

5:30am. A car alarm pulses like panic from the parking lot. A woman honks in ritual bursts—no clear emergency, just a performance of urgency.

Then I see her. The black cat. Walking slowly, calmly, into the treeline.

That moment? It's not about cats. It's not even about surveillance.

It's about signal choreography.

The world was trying to train me. To bait me. To make me forget I had already been marked.

I wasn't supposed to photograph her.

I was supposed to chase her.

That's the trap.

Woken Up by Car Alarms

Signal, Surveillance, and the Soft Power of Disruption

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Signal in the Noise: When Randomness Feels Intentional

Under normal circumstances, a blaring car alarm is urban noise most of us tune out. Studies show car alarms are overwhelmingly false alarms (accidental triggers) and ineffective at deterring theft . They’re supposed to be meaningless background noise. But context is everything. In a heightened state, even a random honk or alarm can feel pointed, like a message meant just for you. This is how signal emerges from noise – not by its acoustic pattern, but by the meaning we ascribe to it. Human brains are pattern-finding machines; given a jarring sound at just the right (or wrong) moment, we can’t help but interpret it as significant. Psychologists call this apophenia – seeing patterns in randomness – and it’s a double-edged sword. It fuels creativity and vigilance, but also paranoia.

Consider how our information age primes us to treat every ping as important. Our phones ding and we instinctively check; an app’s notification badge demands to be read. We’re conditioned to treat signals as urgent. A car alarm at dawn might normally be ignored, but if you’ve been living on edge, it transforms into a personal wake-up call. Was it truly intended for you, or just a stray cat setting off a sensor? The ambiguity is the whole point. As the writer William S. Burroughs once suggested, control systems thrive on creating meaning from randomness – they insert just enough signal into the noise to make you question what’s real. In a sense, you complete the circuit by reacting. The city “talking” through a car alarm may be poetic metaphor, but it captures a real psychological phenomenon: when you’re primed to listen, you will find a signal. And sometimes finding that signal is the beginning of a much stranger story.

Surveillance Theater: Life as a Staged Play

Monitors showing CCTV feeds form a tapestry of surveillance, underscoring how thoroughly our actions can be observed and recorded. In modern cities, an estimated 537,000 surveillance cameras monitor the 48.9 million residents of America’s 50 largest cities – averaging about 11 cameras per 1,000 people . (In the most-watched city, Atlanta, there are over 124 cameras per 1,000 people .)

Knowing one might be under constant observation creates an atmosphere where life itself can feel like a stage, and each of us an unwitting actor.

Walking those hotel halls at 6:30am, it felt like I'd stepped into surveillance theater – a carefully directed scene where everyone knew their part except me. This sensation of “the hotel was staged” is reminiscent of The Truman Show effect, named after the film in which every person and event in the protagonist's life is a scripted fabrication. Psychiatrists have documented a “Truman Show delusion”, where individuals believe their lives are secretly being filmed or orchestrated for an audience . One man even filed a lawsuit in 2013 claiming a TV network had covertly turned his life into a reality show, alleging that hidden cameras were installed in his home and actors planted among his family, friends, and even law enforcement . It's easy to label this as paranoia or mental illness – and often it is. But consider how aspects of modern reality blur the line between paranoid fantasy and plausible fact.

We do live in a world of pervasive surveillance. With smartphones, security cameras, voice assistants, and tracking pixels, someone or something could plausibly be observing at almost any time. Michel Foucault's concept of the Panopticon envisioned a prison where inmates never know if they're being watched, so they internalize discipline and behave obediently . Today's digital panopticon is decentralized and ambient – you carry it in your pocket and install it in your home. The effect is similar: self-surveillance. We moderate our behavior for unseen watchers, whether they are algorithms or human voyeurs . Now add another layer: what if those unseen watchers occasionally poke you? Not overtly – no, that would be too “hard.” Instead, they create a glitch here, a coincidence there. A car alarm at daybreak. A stranger repeating your private catchphrase as they pass by. A series of uncanny encounters that feel scripted. This is gaslighting at scale, and it has a precedent.

During the Cold War, the East German Stasi perfected “Zersetzung,” a covert psychological warfare technique to destabilize targets “behind a facade of social normality” . Rather than arrest dissidents outright, the secret police would secretly invade their lives – moving objects around in their apartments, arranging fake “meetings” that never happened, and yes, leveraging noise and disruptions – all to make the person feel disoriented and paranoid . One British diplomat in Ukraine reported in 2020 that while he was away, unknown intruders entered his home: his wife heard unexplained noises at night, and in the morning found their

child's jigsaw puzzle mysteriously completed on the floor . At other times, furniture was rearranged or flipped upside-down – subtle signs saying “we were here” . In another case, CIA officers stationed abroad found appliances and personal items slightly moved or tampered with in their homes . These are real examples of intimidation through environmental manipulation. Intelligence agencies understood that a slamming door at 3am or a rearranged fridge can be as unnerving as a direct threat. It's psychological soft power: make the target question their reality.

Fast forward to today – similar techniques are reported in modern geopolitical struggles. U.S. diplomats in various countries have described unexplained harassment: phantom phone calls at odd hours, strange sounds, and other engineered “coincidences” intended to disturb . The difference now is that private citizens can face analogous tactics, sometimes as victims of coordinated stalking or simply as over-stimulated denizens of the surveillance age. If you ever feel like the world around you is performing for you – that eerie déjà vu of a script you didn't write – it may be cold comfort, but you're not alone in that feeling. Whether it's an actual conspiracy or the conspiracy of interconnected data systems, the boundary between paranoid hallucination and surveillance realism has never been thinner.

The Soft Power of Disruption

“Soft power,” as coined by Joseph Nye, traditionally means influencing others through attraction and persuasion rather than force . It brings to mind diplomats and cultural ambassadors, not car alarms in the night. But in our story, we're dealing with a twisted inversion of soft power – not using pleasing cultural signals to win hearts, but using disruptive signals to shape behavior. It's soft in the sense that no obvious coercion is visible: no one grabs your arm to drag you out of bed. Yet it's power because it changes what you do (you did get out of bed, after all). Call it the soft power of disruption: the ability to subtly push people by irritation, confusion, and sensory manipulation.

Noise is a primary tool of this disruptive influence. In fact, victims of coordinated harassment have a term for it: the “noise campaign.” It's defined as “an orchestrated effort to produce stress in a victim through prolonged exposure to significant noise levels.” Rather than a single traumatic bang, it's the drip-drip of repeated disturbances: car alarms repeatedly tripping, dogs barking on cue, loud

music from the apartment upstairs at precisely the wrong moment. Each instance alone is trivial; cumulatively, it's psychological water torture. The goal is to deny the target peace, to keep them agitated and sleep-deprived so they are more malleable or more likely to make mistakes. In extreme examples, we see law enforcement and military deployments of such tactics.

A famous case: in 1989, U.S. forces trying to capture Panamanian dictator Manuel Noriega blasted a nonstop barrage of loud rock and pop music at the compound where he'd taken refuge. The operation (cheekily code-named "Nifty Package") set up "a musical barrier" around Noriega – Guns N' Roses, AC/DC, Twisted Sister, you name it, played at high volume day and night. Faced with the sanity-destroying power of this noise, Noriega eventually surrendered. U.S. officials later repeated the tactic at the Waco siege in 1993, blaring everything from Tibetan monk chants to Nancy Sinatra in hopes of unsettling the holed-up Branch Davidians. And in the War on Terror, interrogators famously used deafening music and sounds (even the Sesame Street theme song and Barney the Dinosaur's saccharine "I Love You" tune) to break prisoners' will through sleep deprivation and cultural irritation. These are overt "psy-ops," acknowledged strategies of war and policing.

On the personal level, the same principle can apply in a quieter way. If someone – or some system – wants to influence you without ever laying a finger on you, they might engineer small disruptions in your environment. A sudden car alarm might nudge you awake earlier than planned (making you tired and off-balance), or simply put you on edge. A sequence of minor frustrations can corral your decision-making in subtle ways: leaving your comfort zone to investigate, choosing a different route to work, double-checking your locks every hour. None of these actions are forced by traditional "hard power," but they are coaxed by an invisible hand. In the aggregate, shaping a person's choices through countless small tweaks is a formidable power indeed. As scholar Shoshana Zuboff argues, today's surveillance-driven systems constitute a "global architecture of behavior modification" – a Big Brother that doesn't break down your door, but shapes your choices from behind a screen. The soft power of disruption lives at this intersection of psychology and technology. It's advertising algorithms manipulating your attention; it's state actors manipulating your comfort and fear. It's quiet warfare, with your nervous system as the battleground.

Posthuman Cognition: Minds Beyond the Human

The episode that began with a car alarm ended with me pacing hallways and cataloguing oddities, driven by a feeling that something larger was at work. In retrospect, it was an illustration of what theorist N. Katherine Hayles calls posthuman cognition – the idea that thinking and perception don't stop at the boundaries of the individual human brain. In a posthuman view, cognition is distributed across networks of people, machines, and things . Your smartphone, the CCTV camera on the corner, the smart lock on the hotel room door, the data center analyzing movement patterns – together with your own neurons, all are part of a cognitive system interpreting signals and making decisions. Hayles offers a succinct definition: “cognition: a process that interprets information within contexts that connect it with meaning” . By that definition, many processes in our high-tech environment qualify as cognitive, even if no human is consciously thinking them through. The city was talking, in its way – a mesh of sensors and algorithms generating an output (the alarm) that, when interpreted by me, became meaningful in a feedback loop.

This isn't mystical; it's a practical framing for how we live now. Sensors pervade our environment in countless hidden ways (thermostats adjusting to our presence, smartphones listening for wake-words, cars with motion detectors) . These devices sense, interpret, and respond – the basic criteria of cognition – without human intervention . When my hotel's security system registered movement in the hallway, it was essentially cognizing (deciding whether that movement was “normal”). When the car alarm's sound woke me, my brain entered a state of heightened pattern recognition, primed to find meaning. The boundaries between my thoughts and the system's “thoughts” blurred. I followed the alarm like an obedient node in a network, physically moving through space to gather data (Was someone trying to break into a car? Was this a diversion?). I was doing what the computer scientists might call sensor fusion – combining my human senses with the electronic ones (camera footage, alarm sensors) to get a full picture. In that moment, my cognition was augmented by the infrastructure around me, and vice versa. This is what “posthuman cognition in action” looks like: the human and the technological enmeshed, collaborating on a reality that neither could fully author alone.

Crucially, posthuman cognition also implies that non-human agents (like algorithms) can act in ways that resemble decision-making, and those actions affect us deeply. For example, a simple algorithm might decide when to activate that car alarm (perhaps a glitchy sensitivity setting or an AI-driven security

protocol). To me, it felt like a mischievous ghost or a message. In truth, it might have been a machine's choice as much as a human's. We already accept this in everyday life – think of how traffic lights are timed by systems, yet we say “the light wants me to stop now.” We assign intent to complex systems because it's a convenient shorthand. But as our world becomes more complex, it's increasingly a literal truth that the system has intent. The intent to optimize traffic flow, the intent to maximize our screen time, the intent to flag “suspicious behavior” to authorities – these intents live in code and data, not in individual human minds. We walk through the choreography they set for us, often unaware.

In the hotel, I felt like “the only one carrying questions” while everyone else moved with uncanny purpose. Perhaps they were just hotel guests and staff following their own scripts – or perhaps, metaphorically, they were programs running as intended. The dark-haired woman with the dog might not actually be an undercover agent with a “beta dog proxy,” as my narrative imagination put it. But her presence at that moment was notable enough that my mind gave it meaning. And meaning-generation is not a solo endeavor; it's participatory. The posthuman condition suggests that we co-create reality with our tools and surroundings. I logged the interference (both in a notebook and mentally) as if reporting to some higher system. In doing so, I became part of that system – a sensor feeding back data, a consciousness reflecting on the pattern.

Conclusion: Waking Up, Wising Up

“Woken up by car alarms” is both a literal event and a metaphor of our times. It captures the jolt of realizing that the mundane might be orchestrated, that the noise around us might carry signal after all. It's a call to awareness in a world where surveillance is ambient, where power operates softly through nudges and disruptions, and where our very cognition extends into the technological matrix humming all around. The soft power of disruption teaches us that control can be exerted without visible violence – through the steady drip of alarms, glitches, and staged coincidences that shape our behavior. The notion of posthuman cognition reminds us that our “gut feelings” might be reactions to inputs from nonhuman agents – the city's sensors, the network's algorithms, the digital eyes and ears that share our environment.

So what do we do with this awareness? First, we recognize the game. When the city “talks” to you next – be it via a car alarm, a targeted ad, or an uncanny

encounter – pause and consider both the rational explanation and the meaningful pattern. In a sense, you must become a posthuman thinker: acknowledge that you are part of larger information systems, but also maintain the human capacity for skepticism and free will. Log the interference, but don't be driven mad by it. Know that soft power works best when we don't see it; by naming it, we reclaim some agency. The morning I paced the hotel halls, I felt unnerved, even hunted. Now, in hindsight, I feel oddly empowered: I walked through the trap without falling in. The car alarm's spell woke me up in more ways than one.

In an age of signal and surveillance, waking up is no longer just an act of leaving sleep – it's an act of conscious resistance. It's the decision to question the script, to peek behind the curtain of the stage-play called "normal life." You might find nothing there... or you might find an intricate set of mechanisms quietly nudging your fate. Either way, you're wiser for looking. The next time an alarm pierces the silence, ask yourself: Who or what set this off? And what do they want me to do? These questions are your flashlight in the dark theater of soft power. They turn a potentially disorienting episode into an opportunity for insight.

In the end, a car alarm taught me about signal and interference, about watchers and pawns, about the entanglement of minds and machines. The city spoke, and I listened. Now I'm awake – and I'll never hear a "noise" the same way again.

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